ONE WINDOW, TWO VIEWS

Mehrunnisa Khatun, *32*

South 24 Parganas, West Bengal

Supervisor, Self Help Groups

Constituency: Jadavpur

Issues that will decide her vote: Employment opportunities, a general consensus within her family

Demands from the govt: A safer environment to vote, curb inflation



DEBAJYOTI CHAKRABORTY



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Mehrunnisa works as a supervisor of 250-odd self-help groups (SHGs) that operate in Polerhat-I gram panchayat under Bhangar-II block. Mafuza is a member of one such SHG. In spite of their common endeavour to gain financial independence, their voting choices reflect a complete contrast, dictated as they are, among other factors, by their husbands.

Mehrunnisa believes that there is little independence for the people of Bhangar to exercise their franchise, pointing to incidents of political violence. She accuses the incumbent Trinamool Congress (TMC) government of misgovernance and says that there is a growing acceptance of Prime Minister Narendra Modi. But according to Mafuza, the women-centric schemes of the Chief Minister Mamata Banerjee-led TMC regime, like the direct benefit transfer of honorarium under Lakshmir Bhandar, have improved their lives. What both do agree on is for any incoming government to curb inflation, which is making it difficult for households to manage budgets all around. ■

–Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

Mafuza Bibi, *26*

Member, Self Help Group

Issues that will decide her vote: Welfare schemes for women, Muslim women's safety, but ultimately her husband's consent

Demands from the govt: Curb price rise, provide better job opportunities

Part of an agricultural household, Vilasben is the wife of a former sarpanch, who is also an office-bearer of the Bharatiya Janata Party (BJP) at the taluka level. Though her loyalty clearly lies with the saffron party, she is in two minds this time about voting for it. The reason being the ongoing Kshatriya stir in Gujarat after Union minister Parshottam Rupala's controversial remarks against the erstwhile princely states.

Even as a saffron flag bearing Lord Ram's image flutters outside her house, Vilasben insists core Hindutva issues, like the Ram temple construction and the abrogation of Article 370, never influenced her vote. "Women are safe in Gujarat. We can work, go out alone. That is important to me," she says, adding that her village has seen unprecedented development in recent years.

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A mother of two sons, Vilasben says that the construction of concrete roads and connectivity to urban centres has helped her children get good education and work opportunities. It's because of such factors, she says, that her family has been supporting the BJP all these years. ■

–Jumana Shah